He was tall, slim and fair. His eyes were almost blue, and his nose sharp. Later I was told his name was M L Sharma IPS, an inspector general of CBI from Delhi. He radiated authority and intelligence in equal measure. He came to me as if to ask me something, but stopped himself. Abruptly he turned back and left in the same pace he had come in. He entered the adjacent 'room' where Sasi and Chandrasekhar were lodged. I could not see what was happening there, but could hear every sound.

Suddenly the CBI officer was shouting. 'You bastard, you sold the nation to the enemies. You call yourself a scientist … how do you call yourself an Indian first?'

Sasi was saying something, but his voice was so feeble that I could not make out what it was.

There came Sharma's voice again. 'You speak about law? If I am convinced that you have done this crime, I will make sure that you will spend the rest of your life behind bars.'

Then he turned his ire towards Chandrasekhar. For a few minutes, the CBI officer's voice reverberated through the building.

Something told me that Sasi had met the Maldivian women earlier, and that he had done something—though definitely not espionage—that gave the police a reason to link ISRO with the Maldivians and the cooked up case. I was angry with Sasi for having landed me in this cesspool, and even felt a tinge of glee when Sharma shouted at Sasi. I was also scared of this officer though I had nothing to hide.

Sharma marched out of Sasi's 'enclosure', his boots making the tap-tap sound that added to his authority. Sensing my fear, Darshan Singh came and sat by my side.

'Saab, if you have done no crime, you have nothing to worry. Sharmaji is such a great person that he will find out the truth, and he would hurt no innocent,' Singh said.

The old man, now wearing a white kurta-pyjama, was such a contrast from the Kerala police constables that I doubted whether Singh is really working for an investigating agency. During the rest of my stay there, Singh made sense of his demeanour: He had seen it all—people who were